

Learning by Playing: an Ethnographic Account of Building 21

At the street corner of University and Sherbrooke there exists a place known by some as Building 21. Building 21 is largely nondescript in its outward appearance, although upon closer observation one might notice a distinct turquoise door which seems to foreground the building against those around it. As I enter Building 21 through this door today, I quickly find myself surrounded by an excited crowd of others packed tightly together in a narrow kitchen. I add a food contribution to a counter already stocked generously with other dishes before turning to greet the host of people around me.

For eight weeks during the summer, B21 offers some basic provisions for a small cohort of student scholars to explore any given set of ideas in any way that they find relevant to do so. Today, like every Thursday, people have gathered to briefly share some of the ongoing developments taking place in their research through a presentation event known as the 'lightning talks'. These talks punctuate the weekly rhythm of life at Building 21, as they facilitate the confluence of the people and ideas that make up the space. While this gathering affords the opportunity for people to make intellectual sense of their ideas by presenting them to others, they are also distinctly social occasions. Here, students commune and catch up on the personal and pragmatic dealings that they have encountered throughout the previous week, while simultaneously reflecting on the dynamic order of their own lives. In this way, ideas are given new flesh as they are placed in dialogue with concerns which are not merely theoretical in scope, but which come to encompass affective, interpersonal, political, and practical concerns as well. These weekly events seem to disclose one of Building 21's central ambitions in its most augmented form: that is, to cultivate the conditions which are necessary for a more intimate

intellectual community to emerge within the context of a large research university.

Yet, implicit within this observation, lies a whole set of assumptions which already presuppose a great deal about what places of education can and should do for students. Perhaps most fundamentally, Building 21 is premised upon the idea that the standard order of higher education fails to respond to the variety of ways in which learning takes place. Accordingly, other alternative educational environments must be realized in order to better account for the many means by which students learn. This paper seeks to consider the implications of this basic assumption. In devoting ethnographic attention to Building 21, I firstly aim to identify and explicate the central features of its educational ethos. After considering these key attributes, I will then turn towards examining the B21 project through a more critical lens. To this end, I seek to provide some thoughts on the various shortcomings and latent, limiting ideologies found within the space. I will conclude in my analysis by turning to consider what it could mean to integrate spaces like Building 21 into other contexts of work and learning. This exploration seeks to respond at once to the question of what spaces like Building 21 make possible, and likewise, to the question of what the value of Building 21 and adjacent projects ultimately is.

My own encounter with Building 21 took place at the end of my time as an undergraduate at McGill. Like many others, I heard about the space by word of mouth from a friend. As others iterated to me at various points, the experience of 'stumbling upon' the space serves as a common means by which people come to be involved with B21. This notion of the accidental encounter seems to be quite revealing about the kind of space that Building 21 is, as it highlights the fact that B21 goes to no special lengths to advertise its presence. Instead, the space

seems to operate under the assumption that those who are 'meant' to be here will find their way here of their own accord. Or perhaps more accurately, that those who congregate here will continue to invite others into the space and cultivate a community in the process of doing so. The idea of community, and Building 21 as a learning community, represents a central way in which the space is envisaged. As such, I will continually revisit these notions so as to most closely address the question of what Building 21 is, and what it does for people.

Before turning to consider the key attributes which make Building 21 what it is, I think it would be useful to reflect on the circumstances which brought it about to begin with. What instigated the creation of the space? Who had a part in organizing it? What were some of the initial ambitions for this project? Anita Parmar served as an initial point of contact as I thought about these questions. Anita has acted as one of B21's co-directors since its inception in 2017. Her own involvement with B21 began in collaboration with former Deputy Provost and fellow co-founder Ollivier Dyens. In her words, "Building 21 began with a few strokes of luck. Ollivier believed in the notion of creating something different, and I had complete freedom to create what I thought was needed. The first year felt like we were feeling around in the dark, you'd meet someone and then another person and then another who all have the same intuition about creating something that doesn't yet exist."

Much of Building 21's formative first year served as an experiment in figuring out how to exist within the greater context of McGill, and in negotiating what it could and should offer to students. In her work as co-director, Anita noted how she frequently thought back to her own time as an undergraduate at McGill as she worked on figuring out the kinds of student needs that B21 could intend to meet.

"[I remembered] my own dissatisfaction with the educational system, of not finding it to be challenging enough, and yet being overwhelmed. It's easy to forget about your own intuitions when you're in school. I think Building 21 gives people the chance to connect what they're learning in the classroom with their own subjective experiences and perspectives on the world. When I think back to my time at McGill, I mostly remember the friendships that I formed, and the things that I learned from others. This place also makes it more immediately possible for people to form these connections, and to learn in new, unexpected ways."

Anita's reflection brings to mind some of the key discrepancies which are commonly referred to in order to describe how learning takes place. This process could be envisaged as a constant movement, whereby the learner seeks to realize different capabilities, and to have various needs met. Chiefly, this movement can be characterized as an oscillation between absorbing personal and impersonal kinds of information, of entering into spaces defined by intellectual structure and those marked by indeterminacy, and in learning both amongst others and in solitude. It is in locating a unique middle ground between these various educational extremes that it becomes possible for one to learn in a way that is both coherent and meaningful. However, as Anita's comment also underscores, the realization of this ideal can be precluded by the various (and often arbitrary) structures which govern normative academic settings.

This sense of dissatisfaction with the burdens of the educational system, coupled with a desire to explore alternative ways of learning, provided much of the impetus for Anita and others to inaugurate a program known as BLUE. The BLUE program allows students to work on any academic project of their choosing for eight summer weeks. BLUE supports students coming from both undergraduate and graduate backgrounds, and cultivates

an interdisciplinary environment which actively seeks to bring people from different disciplines into contact with one another. As Anita iterated to me on numerous occasions, she believes that there is great value in creating interdisciplinary learning environments, as they expose people to unfamiliar perspectives which in turn enable people to more creatively and thoroughly consider their own primary questions.

I found myself struck by Anita's distinct sense of curiosity in her presence at Building 21. In her interactions with different projects and people, she seemed to have amassed at least a small bit of knowledge about essentially any discipline. This curiosity enables her to at once hear and enter into the ideas that students bring into B21. At the same time, she maintains a strong interest in the ideas and outlooks afforded by her own background in physics, and frequently chooses to return to these perspectives in light of what others share with her. In her words,

"I think that this space is absent of judgment. I think it's important to have space to play with your ideas without the fear of being judged. Judgment can look like many things: being graded, being laughed at, being excluded. We'll only respect you more for saying something 'way out there'. Curiosity is encouraged here."

Put otherwise, the cultivation of an openness to people and their perspectives represents one of Building 21's key ambitions, insofar as this serves as a basic condition of possibility for the development of new ideas and creative outlooks. Anita's wide-reaching interests and attitude of encouragement directly embodies this intention, and it is because of the ambition that she brings to the space that this ideal is continually reaffirmed.

The relationships that exist between Anita and the broader amalgamation of people, activities, and things which constitute Building 21 caused me to consider the ways in which others brought their own meanings into the space. What exactly is the connection between the people and place of B21? Do people primarily define the kinds of things that happen here, or does the physical space itself dictate what people can do? Or perhaps more accurately, how do these apparently distinct domains interact and co-constitute each other? And more basically, what is actually being referred to in discussing the Building 21 project?

The 2019 iteration of the BLUE program brought together 16 fellows, collectively working on 14 different projects. Each scholar was granted access to the same basic set of provisions: access to the Building 21 space, the resource of other people to work alongside, and a monetary stipend of \$3,000. Though each scholar was given the same initial set of conditions through which to realize their projects, the ways in which these resources were utilized and allocated seemed to differ greatly from one person to another. As I noted these attributes, a certain existential question came to mind, that is, how do we make choices through and with the everyday circumstances which have been set out for us, without our choosing?

One scholar, Iris, chose to spend much of the first half of the program absorbing ideas while in conversation with others. Her project on ADHD and its configuration within ordinary educational infrastructures prompted her to probe the other fellows about the particular challenges and preferred strategies in their own educational experiences. As BLUE continued, she noted a growing frustration with her own abilities to, "externalize internal ideas." The complexity and ambition of her project at first seemed to inhibit her from finding any significant traction with which to 'plant' her ideas. At Anita's

suggestion, she chose to pick out a small, quiet hallway in the building to map her ideas onto large sheets of paper taped to the wall.

With this gesture, the trajectory of her work shifted significantly. Here, she found leeway which gave new legitimacy to her ideas. This designated space set her work apart from the other projects, and in turn allowed her to envisage her ideas in more concrete, legible terms. This corner became charged with a kind of ritual significance, as she found herself able to intentionally retreat from the rest of her surroundings and into a more directed state of concentration. This instance seems important to point out, as it underscores the significance of the relation between place and person at B21. Iris' actions represent a distinct appropriation of the resources present at Building 21, a condensation of the things made available to her into a practice which made sense to use within the context of her own work and interests. It is in the act of using what's given to us that we familiarize ourselves with our lived conditions, and in turn come to inhabit the always-changing contexts of our own lives.

This notion of ritualization was echoed by others in the ways that they chose to make use of their time during the fellowship. Another scholar, Laura, took an interest in exploring acts of listening within her project. She noted her dissatisfaction with some of the limitations associated with prescriptive practices of listening in her work within psychiatry, namely in its inclination to pathologize and over-intellectualize everyday psychological states. To this end, her project drew upon methodologies which privileged sensory, bodily, and affective modes of listening. Much of her work during the program involved seeking out practices and spaces in which listening could be explored in this capacity. As time progressed, she began to introduce her own listening experiments

at B21. This involved a wide range of activities ranging from text reading, to improvisational performance exercises, to dance movements. Each workshop that she hosted was distinctly collaborative, and much of her own understanding about what it means to listen came to be derived from the feedback that others provided about their experiences here. In this way, the people who comprise B21 became an indispensable resource for Laura, as her work took shape not in isolation, but through and with others.

I began to give thought to the more indeterminate features of Building 21. The spontaneous conversations and moods which permeate this place and curate its unique atmosphere. How else do people make use of Building 21? What other resources are available for people to draw upon? In what other ways do people enact ritual or create their own idiosyncratic schemas of order out of obscurity? Matthew, a student who had recently completed the first year of his undergrad degree, found the unique affordance of the BLUE program to be a rich opportunity to learn more about his own learning process. As he told me,

"One of the things that I've noticed are the many stages that I've gone through in perceiving and acting out information. There's the stage of perceiving, for instance in reading, and then the stage of digesting, for instance in speaking with others. There's 'good enzymes' to digest information here. And then I think the final stage is acting out that information, and that happens for me through writing. Have I actually been able to respect this pattern? I don't know... I think this was really well shown through my concept map, that they get so big that the boundaries of my project just keeps on expanding. When it becomes too complex or unstable, a new concept map enters the picture, one that can gather and comprehend the information better."

Building 21 makes it possible for people to think about how they think. And as Matthew notes, this is something that happens largely because of the encompassing sense of possibility infused into the social order of B21: something which in turn causes people to interrogate and reframe the very means by which they think and ask questions to begin with.

Each of these vignettes reveals something about the constituent elements which make up life at Building 21. As people draw upon the resources of space, other people, and their own analytic and organizational strategies, B21 comes into being in tandem with the ambitions and approaches that people bring with them. In this way, I think the question of 'what Building 21 fundamentally is' could be better asked by questioning what people are doing here, and how and why they choose to do what they do. It is in learning to inhabit the space that people likewise learn how to inhabit the territory of their own ideas, and the many ambiguities that come along with this terrain.

A Critical Turn

In the preceding section, I provided a brief account of some of the ways in which people choose to engage with the resources that are present at Building 21. Here, I began to think about what B21 offers students, and some of the associated practices and ideas that this in turn gives rise to. In this section of my analysis, I would like to move beyond these observations in order to more critically assess the various protocols, ideologies, and realities which B21 is obligated to contend with in order to ensure its continued existence. This section seeks to shed more critical light on the administrative dynamics which go unquestioned at Building 21 -some of which contradict and impede the kinds of learning opportunities that it aims to make possible for students. My critical reading of B21 will give focus to three dynamics which seem to be inconsistent with the intended purpose of the space. I will first consider the pervading sense of exceptionalism which exists at Building 21, and how this curates an environment that is necessarily exclusionary -sometimes at the cost of turning away outsiders who may be able to offer valuable contributions to the space. From here I will give attention to a prominent

criticism raised during the summer BLUE program: that of the lack of structure here. In exploring this dynamic, I hope to better understand how and why structure can be advantageous in the process of realizing creative ideas, and to what degree (if any) Building 21 might be obligated to offer a structured learning environment to people. My criticism will conclude by thinking about Building 21's broader situation within McGill. Here, I seek to investigate the doubled role that B21 plays: at once offering an experimental learning environment to students while also making itself recognizable to the university as a more normative educational project. I take interest here in considering how this might inhibit the realization of some of B21's more ambitious goals as it presents itself to the university as such.

As I began to think about the fundamental qualities which make Building 21 what it is, I asked people to offer descriptions of the space in their own words. One idea which was referenced in nearly every interpretation underscored the fact of B21's social exclusivity within the broader McGill setting. In order to maintain its small, community-oriented atmosphere, B21 must necessarily limit the amount of people who enter into the space. Indeed, B21 goes to no lengths to advertise its presence, as people instead hear about it by word of mouth. However, not only does B21 forego any kind of advertising, it also makes certain efforts to exclude some people from entering to begin with. During several staff meetings, the administrative team went to considerable lengths to discuss who should have access to the space, and what kinds of permissions this access might entail. As a unique project within McGill, Building 21 selectively offers its space to other kinds of adjacent groups within the university. While this gesture certainly exemplifies a kind of generosity, it comes along with hyper-vigilance towards any minute changes that are made within the space. After one student group utilized the space and failed to fully clean

up after their meeting, the staff met to discuss how the space should be lent out in the future -ultimately concluding that should not be able to use the space without the presence of someone from the B21 administrative team.

In some ways this kind of vigilance make sense. Building 21 exists in its infancy within the wider McGill infrastructure, and as such it is subject to closer scrutiny by higher administrative powers. Any minor offense could easily lead to the discontinuation of the project, hence the need to control what takes place here. At the same time, this oversight can have a patronizing effect on those who come here. On several other occasions, I saw friends of B21 fellows (including my own) turned away from the space on the grounds that "B21 is not a café", or in other words, on the grounds that this space is only for those who have earned a designated right to be here. This cautionary watchfulness seems to be at odds with the primary means by which B21 attracts people to begin with, that is, by allowing people to 'stumble upon' the space accidentally or upon the suggestion of others. If Building 21 aims to foster an organic, collaborative learning environment, what does it mean that these barriers to entry foreground how people are allowed into the space to begin with? I make this observation not to criticize the exercise of *any* selectivity in the space, but rather to point out the fact that this kind of surveillance may actually reinforce the stifling effect that the university can cast upon people's learning processes.

Students like Damian, who has made use of the space since his 2018 BLUE fellowship (and who worked as a supporting staff member during the 2019 program), told me more about the kind of social exclusivity that B21 finds itself impelled to uphold. From his perspective, Building 21 must necessarily close its doors to some students, in large part because of its limited financial and spatial resources. Furthermore, given that B21

seeks to maintain a small-scale environment, it cannot logistically allow many people in. Importantly, Damian also pointed out that this self-selection process already happens of its own accord, as certain people become interested in the space, while others do not. My time with Damian proved fruitful in many regards, not least because of the fact that he came from an anthropology background as well. On many afternoons during the fellowship, we found ourselves in the kitchen together, informally sharing different interpretations of Building 21 over tea. One idea which surfaced at different points during our conversations pertained to the notion of Building 21's existence as a utopia of sorts. By this, we referred to the pervading sense of idealism that can be found here: something which at once instills a great deal of ambition in what people imagine they can do at B21 -sometimes at the cost of causing people to forget the pragmatic dynamics associated with realizing their given projects. As Damian related to me, "BLUE is a time to explore any idea that you have without any superimposed limitation, all the while knowing that you won't be able to do everything that you want to do. I think the most insightful projects are those that don't get too caught up in the fact that they won't be finished by the time that the program is over."

This competition between structured and unstructured modes of work represents an essential point of tension for those who spend their time at Building 21. As I watched different projects come together with varying degrees of success over the course of the summer, I heard some people reference the challenges of realizing their ideas in a context where structure was not given in the same way that it might be within a usual academic setting. This concern was raised especially by those still in their undergraduate studies, where independent research is not typically undertaken. Peoples' trepidation towards the freeform quality of B21's evidently structureless environment reveals a great deal about the efficacy of university education, namely

that it does not equip students to do intellectual work on their own terms. Anita's vision for the space follows from the premise that Building 21 should necessarily exist as a place where people are not subject to the usual obligations present in their studies. In her view, the value of B21 is derived precisely from the fact that people are free to pursue any interest in any way that they want to. As she related, "There's a value in being lost, in coming to terms with the difficulty of organizing your own ideas. There aren't many other places that this can happen, and so I think it's important that people are allowed to struggle on their own a bit." Along with a select few others, Anita shared with me that she thrives with a certain degree of disorder in her environment, as this enables her to create her own meaningful modes of conduct in place of imposed and seemingly arbitrary rules.

This account gave rise to several questions: is there anything that people are prevented from doing without the provision of any basic work requirements? What are the challenges associated with creating a coherent project in the face of a (theoretically) limitless set of possible paths to realizing said project? And what is the relation between order and latitude, and to what extent (if any) should Building 21 seek to facilitate a balance between the two? I quickly came to realize that Building 21's supposed 'orderlessness' is nowhere as totalizing as it may outwardly appear to be. In many ways, a certain degree of order is in fact inherent here. The limitations of temporal, spatial, and financial resources all play a part in shaping how people enter into Building 21, and how they in turn choose to negotiate the orchestration of their projects. These constraints create a frame within which every activity at B21 takes place, as people explore their ideas relative to the provisions made available to them. This is not to say that people's imaginative capacities are determined by certain material constraints, but rather that these constraints

play a part in influencing the quality of the projects in terms of their depth, ambition, precision, and overall complexity.

As the BLUE program continued throughout the summer, the fellows progressed in their work with varying degrees of fruition. I noticed that certain people seemed more capable of 'tapping into' their creative and intellectual sensibilities (and in turn uniting this exploration with directed actions), while others confronted more prolonged periods of impasse in not quite being able to articulate what they wanted to do or why: something which lead some of these fellows to express their desire for more order within the program. Given that both of these designated 'camps' of people were made to contend with the same structureless working environment, why was it that some were able to more successfully 'leverage' themselves? I think a useful response to this question can be offered by considering how people chose to navigate their work. Of those who found a coherent direction in their work, I noticed a gravitation towards preferred methods for organizing thoughts and visions: a mind map, a large sheet of white paper taped to the wall, a notebook, a collection of voice recordings. Outlets such as these helped people to better externalize their internal (and often nebulous) ideas. As Matthew put it, "You think you have an idea of what you're trying to communicate until you actually try to share it in words. My mind maps have helped me to talk about my own personal ideas in a language that is more publicly accessible." Iris similarly echoed, "Only after Anita suggested that I take up some wall space to jot down my ideas did things start to come together for me. Something about having a designated space to think in changed everything." What these comments suggest to me is the notion that some degree of order, limitation, or structure serves as a basic and inextricable condition of possibility in making abstract ideas intelligible. In my mind, Building 21 should not devote energy towards imposing universal rules which may or may not ultimately prove

to be useful for people. Instead, effort should be given to helping people find tools to better articulate their latent ideas. I agree with Anita in her assessment that there is value to be found in 'the struggle' of organizing one's own ideas, however, I also think that there is a specific extent to which this rings true. Without a way to navigate the terrain of overarching, abstract thought, one will necessarily remain 'in the dark' towards the more nuanced implications of their inquiry. To this end, I would advocate that Building 21 devote more explicit attention towards equipping people with the various tools that they need to outline the borders of their interests and enunciate their ideas.

I seek to bring forward one final point of criticism of Building 21. Here, I would like to give more attention to this space as it is situated within the greater McGill ecosystem. As I spent time with key administrative actors (namely staff members such as Anita and Ollivier, but also with student employees like Damian and Rebecca), I was provided with a picture of how the space is compelled to orchestrate itself under the university's more encompassing bureaucratic infrastructure. I should point out that B21 is in no way separate from or 'other than' McGill, indeed its very presence is afforded by the fact that there is a university with a student population in need of an adjacent space to do intellectual work. As such, I would argue against the imposition of any concrete binary between the two institutions, as they converse and interact in numerous ways. At the same time, Building 21 is different from McGill in that it seeks to offer certain opportunities and educational experiences which cannot be found there.

In thinking about B21's double identity, I began to question why this divide was present to begin with. Why is it that B21 finds itself compelled to provide differing accounts of

itself: as a legible, productive project on the one hand, and as a radical (and often messy) experiment in self-directed learning on the other? These differing performances suggest that there are in fact different audiences which Building 21 must address. To the university, B21 is recognized as a satellite project of a much larger, pre-existing educational infrastructure. Its worth is vested in its capacity to buttress this style of education, and to showcase McGill's commitment to educational innovation to a wider public. This idea echoes other criticisms of a growing neoliberal trend within higher education, whereby the university has become tasked not merely with the duty of educating students, but also of preparing students to enter into a precarious, innovation-oriented job market. To many students, Building 21 exists as a place of respite from the university. Here, people are given the opportunity to work, think, and commune in ways which are undervalued or overlooked by the university altogether. Building 21 offers itself to students as an outlet to learn in ways which are not typically possible at McGill, and as such it functions as a kind of 'anti-university' for students. Indeed, I often thought of my own early experience at Building 21 as one in which I was 'unlearning' what and how I had been taught to learn during my time as an undergraduate in order to better access my creative and 'self-guiding' capabilities.

This dual performance quickly becomes problematic for Building 21 as it makes different kinds of commitments to these differing parties. In seeking to be legitimized by the university as a valid educational project, B21 in turn limits (or at least sways) what students can do here. Likewise, it is in giving students expanded freedom to creatively explore their interests that Building 21 runs the risk of placing itself in conflict with the kinds of educational projects that McGill recognizes as valid and worthy of support. I would argue that this double bind poses a significant limitation to Building 21's

development. Insofar as B21 finds itself obligated to orchestrate its various activities under the watch of the university, to what extent can these activities authentically serve students' educational needs and desires? I pose this question not to speculate what 'authentic' education might mean or look like, but rather as a way to point out some of the ways in which Building 21 contrives itself to meet the greater demands of the university.

Building 21 participates in the process of making itself legible to the university in a number of different ways. One practice that stood out to me in this regard were the podcast recording sessions that took place during the BLUE program. During these podcasts, Rebecca and Damian met with each of the scholars to discuss the scope of their projects. These meetings allowed people to more closely consider the direction of their work, but they also provided B21 with a useful supply of raw material that helps to reveal what this place is and what it does for students. As Rebecca told me, "These podcasts are helpful because they provide a large supply of data that we can share later on. We hope to be able to turn people to these podcasts if they want to know more about B21, they function as something 'deliverable' to this end." The matter of summarizing B21's activities in a 'deliverable' format represents a task to which considerable effort is devoted. The administrative staff also allocates a keen sense of vigilance towards the quality and content of the material that is ultimately shared. During my own podcast, I engaged in an informal conversation with Damian and Rebecca. We meandered from one idea to another while discussing the purpose of my work at B21, incorporating a good deal of humor into the talk all the while. During a staff meeting shortly after, the point was raised that it might be inappropriate to share this podcast interview, given that it came across as somewhat unprofessional and scattered. This event discloses a great deal about the relationship between B21 and

the wider university community: namely that *appearances matter* to Building 21. In other words, it is important for B21 to scrutinize how it comes across to the university, as its continued existence is contingent upon the portrayal of a positive image.

While this kind of vigilance proves efficacious for creating a positive public image, it becomes problematic when it begins to encroach upon how students are able to work. I noticed the manifestation of this screening process in other ways as I spent more time with the administrative team. People shared with me other observations of instances in which they found themselves compelled to talk about B21 in more normative ways to different audiences. For example, Anita noted her own cognizance of 'editing' how she spoke about Building 21 with colleagues elsewhere at McGill. During different meetings with the university, she found herself challenged to describe the project in a coherent manner. When she found herself stuck here, she would sometimes default to using her own personalized language to talk about the value of the space. While this technique seemed to run the risk of coming across as too informal or impassioned, it was often precisely because of this that she received interest and positive feedback from people. As she reasoned, her own authentic voice and attitude offered a means for people to more immediately connect with the project. In sharing her genuine feelings about the importance of B21, others would similarly be able to recognize the value of this project in pragmatic, lived terms. To me, this approach is one that Building 21 needs to take on more readily. If the underlying premise of Building 21 is to give people the opportunity to explore ideas on their own terms, then this commitment must be reflected outwardly as well. To this end, I think that B21 could devote more attention towards cultivating self-sufficiency, that is, finding ways to decrease its dependency upon the university as the sole force which can legitimize what takes place here.

The less that B21 relies upon McGill to permiss what 'alternative learning' can look like, the more freedom it will have to work directly with students to help them think and work in ways that prove meaningful to them. While B21 is inextricably connected to the university, this does not mean that the university has to have a determinative effect on B21's organization. In order to free itself (at least somewhat) from the doubled set of obligations to the university and to students, B21 must seek to define itself on its own terms as much as possible. While I have no specific recommendations as to how this might ultimately be accomplished, I think it is important that B21 to continue to foreground a kind of sincerity and transparency in the work that it does. What draws people to this space is the sense of possibility that can be found here: something which should not be stifled but rather utilized as a great asset in showcasing why B21 matters.

In this section, I chose to devote critical attention to several dynamics which seem to limit Building 21 in its efforts to foster a truly open and experimental learning environment for students. Importantly, these criticisms have largely been directed towards the administration which directs B21. As I see it, it is within the power and realm of responsibility for B21 to become more cognizant of the shortcomings that I have laid out here, and in turn work to address these faults. I should also note that, in many ways, Building 21 is aware of these limitations and that ideas surrounding the 'ideal' way(s) for students to learn is being constantly negotiated by those who make decisions about the organization of the space. I think this kind of dialogue is a positive thing, as the more that people continue to question and contest how B21 could be improved, the more this project stands to empower students to make their own educational choices and to locate a kind of intellectual self-sufficiency while doing so.

Towards a Pedagogy of Play

So far, I have devoted attention to Building 21 as a singular phenomenon that exists within a definite space and context. My observations have explored the dynamics which both enable and limit what B21 is able to afford people. In this final section, I would like to venture beyond thinking about Building 21 in its particular iteration at McGill in order to consider what this project might stand to suggest about the significance of creating other alternative avenues by which we can work, think, collaborate, and create. In attending to these

questions, I am interested in identifying the underlying affordance(s) that B21 grants people, and the significance that these provisions might bring to bear upon how we can work and relate in other contexts. In other words, what does Building 21 make space for, how could this be translated elsewhere, and what might the implications of this be?

In my efforts to describe Building 21, I have oscillated between various terms, describing B21 at different points as a space, a community, a project, and an experiment. Each of these designations yields a certain amount of merit in articulating what B21 is and what it does, and yet none seems to wholly capture what it is. Indeed, as I asked others to describe what Building 21 is, I noticed the same difficulty to articulate Building 21 under one single term. Why does this simple task prove to be so challenging? And what might this stand to reveal about what is fundamentally taking place here? These questions mark a more pointed return to those that I originally raised at the beginning of this paper, where I sought to build a descriptive picture of how people inhabit B21. Whereas my earlier attempts to describe Building 21 were framed by the question of what it is, I now think it would be more pertinent investigate what B21 *does*.

In thinking back to the ethnographic information that I initially brought forward, what did people make of the fact of their presence here? What can we deduce as the common experiences that Building 21 enables and potentiates? And what might this stand to suggest about the unique value that spaces like this can introduce into people's lives? Each interlocutor that I spoke with made note of the fact that their time at Building 21 was one which decidedly privileged 'process over product', which is to say that people were able to focus on *how* and *why* they worked, as opposed to any outcome that their work might bring. This dynamic seemed to emerge in tandem with the

experience of reciprocity that many also cited during their time at B21. Whereas the university experience (particularly at the undergraduate level) tends to overdetermine people in their capacity to exercise their own creative and intellectual agency, Building 21 fosters a conversation between the realm of one's personal ideas and intuitions, and the realm of shared, collaborative discourse. Students have a sense that their ideas hold weight at B21: something which in turn leads to fruition of these ideas, as they are recognized as an integral part of the social and intellectual life that takes place here. As people find the freedom to explore their interests, they in turn enter into relationships of *play*: both with their own ideas and with others.

This notion of play is something that I would like to devote attention to for the remainder of my analysis, as I think it represents the ultimate contribution that places like Building 21 have to offer. But what is play? What does it mean to be playful, and how does play transform what people imagine as being possible within the context of their everyday lives? As I alluded to before, I think it is important to make a conceptual distinction between play as a 'thing' and play as an 'event'. To understand play as a thing, an object, a commodity, or an idea, seems to overlook many of the more ordinary and initial ways in which we come to conduct ourselves in ways which might be considered playful. To apprehend play as an event is to acknowledge how it arises from our situation within the world. Play is something which 'happens', not because we preemptively choose to apply it as our regard towards the world, but rather because it becomes relevant to take on this disposition with the surfacing of particular events. It functions as a means by which we improvise with the circumstances that are given to us, and as such it constitutes a critical means by which we enact agency in the world.

But play is not born out of any kind of encounter with the world. Importantly, it seems to emerge during the interstitial moments ambiguity and uncertainty which permeate the landscape of our everyday lives. These episodes debase our normative attention and attitudes towards the world, as they introduce unexpected situations which invite us to reconsider our prior assumptions about how we can and should organize ourselves. Such events often seem to be vested with unknown (or unknowable) potentiality, as the implications of their meaning remain stowed beyond immediate sight. As we come to terms with the opaque terrain of our lived reality, two general kinds of responses are given the opportunity to emerge. On the one hand, we might choose to succumb to the indeterminacy of what we face: regarding our inability to know as a source of lack or failure. On the other, we might choose to view this indeterminacy as a unique condition of possibility for the emergence of other ways of knowing, creating, thinking, and being. Here, the unfixed quality of things provides a new impetus to explore a range of alternative outlooks and opportunities at will. As we seek to make sense and make do with what is given to us, we in turn begin to play with our given conditions. The indefinite attributes of our lives come to afford us with rich platforms from which it is possible to cultivate new relationalities to the world and ourselves within it.

Building 21 is primed to facilitate a wide variety of playful encounters, as it emboldens people to recognize the many means by which they can engage with their given ideas and interests. The fact that people are freed from the normal academic pressures to progress and produce consistently means that they are also able to lean into the central ambiguities which underpin their interests. This in turn clears space for an involvement with one's work which is more wholly engaged, as one finds latitude to think beyond the mere 'what' a given idea in order to consider the 'how' and 'why' that is at stake in it as

well. This order of reflection activates a kind of responsiveness to one's mental, imaginative, and temporal realities which I think can be characterized as the beginnings of play. This recognition can (and commonly does) elicit an engaged response, whereby one becomes attentive to the fact that one can contribute to a larger ordering of things. Play emerges from these encounters, as we creatively utilize our given situations and limitations in such a way as to explore a greater variety of possible presents and futures.

What would it mean to introduce opportunities for play into other public and professional contexts? In attending to this question, it may first prove worthwhile to acknowledge several notable examples of places where play has occupied a central role in the organization of social life. One of the first examples that comes to mind is Building 20 -the research initiative from which Building 21 takes its name. From 1943-1998, this research incubator at MIT facilitated the development of a number of experimental research projects. Building 20 garnered attention as an 'alternative' research space not merely because of the kind of research that it supported, but also because of how researchers were enabled to explore ideas here. Building 20 challenged the usual academic tendency to compartmentalize and distance the various academic disciplines from one another by bringing together thinkers from across the university under one common roof. This action fostered a network of ongoing dialogues between those who would not ordinarily come into contact with one another: something which subsequently allowed people to examine their own ideas from a variety of new angles, as they found themselves compelled to present their thoughts to new audiences. Another notable example of a place where play has held an integral role in the organization of things is the series of 'Skunkworks' initiatives which have been implemented within various corporate and professional settings. A Skunkworks environment is one which has

been characterized as, "[an] enriched environment that is intended to help a small group of individuals design a new idea by escaping routine organizational procedures." Here, a limited number of people are licensed with the intellectual and creative freedom to experiment with ideas on their own terms. These spaces in turn become the 'innovative backbone' of a company or organization, as they generate insightful, projective visions which can then be implemented by those working elsewhere within the administrative body. More frequently, play is also entering into the workplace, as startup companies incentivize employees with amenities such as unlimited (or at least increased) days off, in the hope that more access to free space and time will in turn lead to greater productivity within the workplace.

This is all to say that Building 21 has emerged from a pre-existing genealogy of other projects which have chosen to privilege play as an important mechanism by which various ideas and aspirations can be advanced. It proves worthwhile to acknowledge this broader context in which B21 exists, as this supports the notion that play is a technique which matters, insofar as it has been utilized as a rich basis from which original thought and action can begin to take shape. So what's at stake in making space for play, particularly within the context of education? And how might we begin to integrate play into the educational context of the university?

These questions bring to mind the growing pressures that universities are placed under to measure student achievement, so as to demonstrate the efficacy of various educational protocols and programs. I would argue that the value of play is something that cannot be measured in an immediate or direct sense. Much of what I garnered from the accounts of the fellows was an understanding that the importance of their projects was less contained in the results that immediately emerged from their work and more in the kinds of possibilities that this work set

in motion. People made continual reference to the fact that their time at Building 21 allowed them to come into contact with their own academic intentions and interests at a more fundamental level. Moreover, the leeway that B21 affords for a kind of trial-and-error in one's learning meant that people were able to gain a thorough sense of what was really conducive to their own thought process. In this way, play performs a subtle but foundational role in conditioning our general outlook towards the world, as it instigates any number of 'shifts' in the ways that we learn, reflect, and relate to others. These shifts may prove insignificant when we consider them individually and within a short-term context, but in time they accumulate and cohere so as to shape the broader arcs by which we choose to go about organizing our lives. This observation underscores the notion that the value of play is something that cannot really be estimated by any conventional metrics. Its value lies in the unanticipated encounters and observations that it brings: something which extends well into the future as play becomes a resource that people can draw upon in order to creatively contend with their everyday circumstances. To this end, I think that Building 21 is valuable insofar as it provides people with an experience that they can recall and turn back to as they venture forward and find themselves in situations which demand the exercise of original thought and inventive problem-solving.

I think there are manifold implications vested in the project of bringing play forward within education. Given the presence of the many stresses which are perhaps an inherent part of the landscape of higher education, play offers an important outlet by which people can tactfully deal with the various pressures which inevitably manifest here. In the same way that we can choose to meet precarity with play, so too can play respond to the stress that comes with feeling overwhelmed by the magnitude of the work that lies before us. To this end, play

might offer a means for people to cultivate a sense of wellness within the university environment, as it could make academic work more manageable by allowing students to step back, reflect, and rethink before turning to take the work up again. In addition to enabling us to work better, I think the inclusion of play within higher education would also lead to the generation of better work. This is to say that play offers a significant means by which we are able to access our creative, imaginal, and intellectual capabilities. As I have iterated at numerous points in my ethnographic observations, the kind of play which takes place at B21 lends itself not merely to pleasure and interpersonal connectedness, but also to the development of ideas. Play allows ideas to take shape more organically, as it privileges an attention to the means by which thought comes into being over any concerns for what might ultimately result from this process. When we are freed from the pressure of needing to realize a specific outcome, we in turn become open to exploring our ideas through a much greater variety of possible avenues: some of which may in fact prove to be more cogent than the original path(s) that we might have had in mind. Play thus acts as a key of sorts, one which is vested with the capacity to unlock some of our richest inner potentials as it activates our abilities to consider things in an alternative light. To fail to make space for play within the university context likewise stands to deprive students of an invaluable mode of access to themselves, that is, a means by which it becomes possible to explore a wider spectrum of one's own capabilities which would otherwise remain unexercised and dormant.

One final and general implication that I think is at stake in making space for play within education stems from its capacity to acknowledge and better accommodate for the wide variety of learning styles that exist. One of the main criticisms that people voiced about the university pertained to

its monolithic tendency to presume that there is a universal way in which learning should take place. I would hope that the ethnographic examples that I have provided have made it abundantly clear that what constitutes 'ideal learning' is something that can look drastically different for different people. As I have noted, play is something which *involves* people, which is to say that it causes people to examine and utilize their own aptitudes in ways that prove relevant, coherent, and meaningful within the context of their own lives. To afford space for play within the university would likewise enable students to engage with academic material more thoroughly, as it encourages one to emplace general information within individual and idiosyncratic frames of reference. I think that this personalization of knowledge through play is something that could also be of value to people well beyond the context of a four-year undergraduate education, as it could serve to foster a degree of intellectual self-sufficiency. If people are given the opportunity to learn on their own terms, I think this will in turn prompt people to initiate their own learning endeavors. As opposed to merely learning to gamify a predetermined educational architecture, to play in learning would mean to claim a kind of responsibility in one's own educational journey, and to integrate knowledge into oneself more fully and foundationally as a result.

My reflections note some of the possible implications that are at stake in integrating play into the landscape of higher education, but what are the potential means by which this could be achieved? To be sure, I do not wish to give off the impression that making space for play is any simple task. In many ways play seems to run counter to our preexisting judgments about how to optimally organize the world, and ourselves within it. Thus, it will be no easy feat to infuse an educational landscape with opportunities for play, though for all of the reasons that I have intimated, I think efforts to do so would

prove worthwhile. One dynamic which I have already alluded to pertains to the metrics by which we measure academic success. Insofar as we remain preoccupied with what is produced by the work that we do, we also tend to overlook the means by which we bring this work into being to begin with. To this end, I think that more attention must be devoted towards devising methods to quantify the 'how' and 'why' in addition to the 'what' of academic work. This could perhaps be facilitated by inviting students to provide reflections of their experiences in working with given materials, and then taking these reflections seriously in assessing how rigorously one has chosen to engage with the work. Space might also be made for play by fostering opportunities for self-direction within education. Academic initiatives such as independent study courses and honors projects already exist to enable this kind of directedness (at least at McGill), though there is certainly more room to forge space for these kinds of opportunities. I think this kind of latitude could be expanded, for instance, by involving students in organization of the academic programs that are made available to them. By equipping students with a sense that they can influence the course of their educational experiences, they will in turn be able to draw upon their preexisting interests as a grounds from which to engage more fully with those domains of inquiry which exist adjacent to these interests.

Perhaps more generally, I think that universities could integrate play into student's educational experiences by viewing education not merely as an intellectual endeavor, but as a social and emotional activity as well. Building 21 underscores the fact that our ability to think in a rigorous, independent manner is something that is in fact conditioned by the broader social landscapes that we inhabit. As such, I think it is pivotal for places of higher education to foster opportunities for people to come together outside of contexts that are strictly academic in nature. This might take place in any number

of ways. Universities could endeavor to offer discretionary funding for people to create events aimed at bringing together people from different parts of the university -perhaps for no other reason than to enjoy a free coffee or lunch. Additionally, I think it would prove worthwhile to devote efforts towards creating physical spaces on campuses where people can congregate to relax, talk, and momentarily step away from their studies. Such spaces could positively fragment the experience of being in a university environment, which some described to me as feeling monolithic and hostile. More formally, I think it is also important to allocate effort towards creating and sustaining spaces like Building 21. Having designated initiatives that are devoted to bringing forward play-centric modes of learning and research are critical if a university is legitimately committed to enabling people to learn in this way. These projects exist as important backbones in forging room for play, as they accord explicit attention to the significance of and the means by which play can occur.

As I have aimed to showcase, play is something that matters. It serves as a valuable everyday technique by which people are enabled to tap into their creative, imaginal, and intellectual capabilities. To make space for play within higher education likewise stands to make room for the myriad ways in which people learn and produce intellectual work. Projects like Building 21 perform a crucial role in emboldening playful encounters and outlooks within settings of higher education, and in turn come to shape the wider terrain in which education takes place. It is also in this process that the pitfalls and purposes of higher education become revealed. Thus, to make space for play is to conceive of the various ways in which higher education stands to be improved, and to make these adjustments accordingly.